DILL PICKLE

Starring

OLLIE BEHNAMI & ELISE SHERRAT



Written & Directed By

AYESHA DOWNES

Produced By

DIANA SMEDLEY & JACOB WEBB

Cinematography By

CALEB GILBERT

Synopsis

YOUNG ASPIRING RAPPER BIG D, WHO IS OFTEN MISTAKEN FOR NICKI MINAJ, IS DETERMINED TO BECOME THE GREATEST RAPPER OF ALL TIME. STRUGGLING FOR INSPIRATION ON HIS WAY HOME, HE BEGINS BRAINSTORMING LYRICS FOR THE GREATEST RAP EVER. HE'S SOON DISTRACTED BY STACY, AN OLDER GIRL FROM SCHOOL, AND MUSTERS UP HIS SWAGGER TO APPROACH HER. STACY WANTS NOTHING TO DO WITH HIM, BUT AFTER AN AWKWARD EXCHANGE AND AN EVEN MORE AWKWARD REJECTION, BIG D'S RELENTLESS CHARM WINS HER OVER. SHE RELUCTANTLY FOLLOWS HIM TO MEET A KIND OLD LADY FOR A SWEET TREAT.

LATER, THE PAIR REUNITE, AND STACY OPENS UP ABOUT HER UNCERTAIN FUTURE AND TROUBLING THOUGHTS. UNSURE WHAT TO MAKE OF HER WORDS, BIG D HOPES SHE'LL ATTEND HIS TALENT SHOW THAT EVENING. WHEN STACY FAILS TO APPEAR, HE PERFORMS HIS RAP AND DEDICATES IT TO HER. AFTERWARDS, HE RETURNS TO THEIR MEETING SPOT AND, FINDING HER ABSENT, LEAVES A RECORDING OF HIS LEGENDARY RAP BEHIND.

LATER, STACY ARRIVES ALONE, LOST IN THOUGHT, UNTIL SHE DISCOVERS THE RECORDING AND CAN'T HELP BUT SMILE. THE FOLLOWING DAY, BIG D SITS ALONE AT LUNCH WHEN STACY JOINS HIM, AND THE PAIR SHARE A HUG. HE OFFERS HER HIS SPECIAL TREAT: A GREEN DILL PICKLE. ALTHOUGH SHE'S FAR LESS ENTHUSIASTIC ABOUT IT THAN HE IS, THEY SHARE A SMALL BUT MEANINGFUL MOMENT OF CONNECTION.

Technical Specs

CHRISTCHURCH, NEW ZEALAND, 2026
DURATION: 13MINS
COLOR
LANGUAGE: ENGLISH
GENRE: DRAMA, COMEDY



DIRECTOR'S NOTE

I THINK ONE OF THE MOST SPECIAL THINGS ABOUT FILMMAKING IS ITS ABILITY TO BRING US INTO SOMEONE ELSE'S WORLD AND HELP US CONNECT WITH EXPERIENCES WE MIGHT NOT OTHERWISE UNDERSTAND. WITH DILL PICKLE, I WANTED TO EXPLORE THE VULNERABILITY OF BEING YOUNG, THE COMPLICATED EMOTIONS AND UNINTENTIONALLY FUNNY MOMENTS THAT COME WITH GROWING UP, AND THE DIFFERENCE THAT CONNECTION CAN MAKE IN SOMEONE'S LIFE.

I BELIEVE THE MOST POWERFUL STORIES ARE OFTEN THE ONES THAT FEEL HUMAN, WITH PIECES OF OURSELVES WOVEN INTO THEM. DILL PICKLE IS CONNECTED TO MANY ASPECTS OF MY OWN CHILDHOOD GROWING UP IN ŌTEPOTI DUNEDIN. IN PARTICULAR, IT DRAWS ON MY EXPERIENCES OF FIRST LEARNING ABOUT SUICIDE AND MENTAL HEALTH AS A YOUNG ADULT, AND TRYING TO SUPPORT SOMEONE I CARED ABOUT WITHOUT REALLY UNDERSTANDING HOW. IT WAS A DIFFICULT THING TO NAVIGATE, AND I CAME TO REALISE THAT SOMETIMES YOU DON'T NEED TO HAVE ALL THE ANSWERS. SIMPLY BEING THERE FOR SOMEONE, BEING YOURSELF, AND MAKING AN EFFORT TO CONNECT CAN MEAN MORE THAN YOU REALISE.

MENTAL HEALTH AND SUICIDE ARE SUBJECTS THAT DESERVE TO BE APPROACHED WITH CARE. I WANTED TO EXPLORE THESE THEMES WITHOUT MAKING A PERSON'S STRUGGLES THE ONLY THING THAT DEFINES THEM. RATHER THAN FOCUSING SOLELY ON THE DARKNESS, I WANTED TO TELL A STORY THAT LEAVES ROOM FOR HUMOUR, CONNECTION, AND HOPE. I THINK IT'S IMPORTANT TO REMEMBER THAT EVEN WHEN THINGS FEEL DIFFICULT, THERE CAN STILL BE MOMENTS OF LIGHTNESS, AND THAT PEOPLE ARE SO MUCH MORE THAN WHAT THEY'RE GOING THROUGH.







ABOUT THE DIRECTOR

AYESHA DOWNES IS AN EMERGING FILMMAKER COMPLETING HER BACHELOR OF DIGITAL SCREEN AT THE UNIVERSITY OF CANTERBURY IN AOTEAROA NEW ZEALAND. HER LOVE FOR FILMMAKING BEGAN AT JUST NINE YEARS OLD, WHEN SHE STARTED MAKING YOUTUBE VIDEOS WITH NOTHING MORE THAN AN IPAD AND A BIG DREAM. WHAT BEGAN AS A CHILDHOOD PASSION HAS GROWN INTO A DEEP LOVE FOR STORYTELLING AND A DESIRE TO BRING HER OWN STORIES TO LIFE.

DRAWN TO STORIES THAT EXPLORE THE COMPLEXITIES OF BEING HUMAN, AYESHA IS PARTICULARLY INTERESTED IN THE SPACE BETWEEN HUMOUR AND HEART. SHE BELIEVES THAT EVEN THE SMALLEST, MOST SEEMINGLY ORDINARY MOMENTS CAN HOLD MEANING, AND THAT THE STORIES WE TELL CAN CHANGE HOW WE SEE OURSELVES AND THE PEOPLE AROUND US.

AFTER SEEING THE RESPONSE TO HER DEBUT SHORT FILM, DHAR'S DAIRY, AYESHA REALISED JUST HOW MEANINGFUL IT CAN BE TO SHARE A STORY WITH OTHERS. SEEING PEOPLE CONNECT WITH SOMETHING SHE HAD CREATED INSPIRED HER TO KEEP MAKING FILMS THAT MAKE PEOPLE LAUGH, CRY, THINK, AND PERHAPS UNDERSTAND ONE ANOTHER A LITTLE BETTER.



CAST

'BIG D' - OLLIE BEHNAMI

'STACY' - ELISE SHERRAT

'GREG' - JOSH WEAR

'MRS OLD LADY' - ANNABELLE WEAR

'JUDGE' - LIV BELLEW

CREW

WRITTEN AND DIRECTED BY - AYESHA DOWNES

PRODUCED BY DIANA SMEDLEY AND JACOB WEBB

CINEMATOGRAPHY BY - CALEB GILBERT

EXECUTIVE PRODUCER - ELLIE ADAMS

EDITOR - AYESHA DOWNES

COLOURIST - CALEB GILBERT

SOUND ENGINEER - IMRAN HAMID

GAFFER - JACK ROBINSON

FIRST ASSISTANT DIRECTOR - JADEN SALKELD

SECOND ASSISTANT DIRECTOR - ROLAND WILLIAMS

FIRST ASSISTANT CAMERA - DANIEL DAVY

SECOND ASSISTANT CAMERA - NATDANAI VARNAKOMALA

LOCATION SOUND - JACOB WEBB

BOOM OPERATOR - BRODIE SIMPSON

ART DEPARTMENT - ANH NHAM & CAOIMHE HUNGERFORD

BTS PHOTOGRAPHER - ALYSSA MURPHY

CONTINUITY - JOSH LUXFORD

DISTROBUTION ENQUIRIES

DIANA SMEDLEY

PRODUCER

DSM131@UCLIVE.AC.NZ

JACOB WEBB

PRODUCER

JWE106@UCLIVE.AC.NZ